

Dead in the Water — Clue Deck

The full set of clues, organized by phase. Each clue has a physical location to hide it in, a tag (□ANNOUNCE□ = must be read aloud when found, □KEEP□ = finder's choice to share or hoard), and a GM note explaining its purpose.

Total: 24 hidden clues + 6 GM auto-reveals + 7 forced Sinner confessions across 5 phases.

How the game flows

Each phase (after Phase 1) runs **search round → discussion round → optional second search → discussion → next phase**. During each discussion round, every player must share **one** clue they found that round, even if it's a □KEEP□ clue. They choose which one. This keeps the game moving when players hoard.

Soft-lock policy: Alexander has authority over which rooms are open. Phase 2 has the most rooms locked; locks lift each phase.

Room access by phase:

Phase	Open	Locked
1	Living room only (briefing)	Everything else
2	Entryway, kitchen, living room, dining area, patio, dock, gazebo, bottom floor	Bedrooms, primary suite
3	All bedrooms, Richard's guest room, plus all of Phase 2's open rooms	Primary suite
4	Primary suite + everything	(nothing)
5	Everything	(nothing)

PHASE 1 — The Discovery (15 min)

No searching. Alexander gathers the family in the living room.

GM auto-reveals (read aloud as Alexander):

1. *"I found Mr. Crookshank in the shallows beside the dock at 7:42 this morning. I've called Dr. Langford — he confirms time of death between 11:30 last night and mid-night."*

2. *"The brass dock cleat at the end of the dock is missing. The bolts are still in the wood. It looks like someone pulled it free."*
3. *"His leather portfolio was found open in the gazebo. The notarized envelope he'd been carrying all weekend is gone."*
4. *"Solomon was on his perch in the gazebo. He has been... vocal."*

Then: each player reads their character sheet privately. Vivi and Sebastian receive their separate "you are involved" cards. Sinners learn their secret. Cody learns about his photo.

End Phase 1 by handing each player their search permit (a printed slip listing which rooms they may enter this phase).

PHASE 2 — First Suspicions (30 min)

Search round 1 (10 min). Discussion (10 min). Second short search (5 min) for any room players want to revisit. Final discussion (5 min).

Hidden clues for Phase 2

CLUE 2-1 • **□ANNOUNCE□** *Location:* Living room — taped to the back of the framed nautical chart of Gig Harbor on the wall shelves (the chart with the cove circled in red — one of Richard's gifts to Hank). *Content card:* A torn corner of paper in Richard's handwriting: *"...told her this afternoon. She took it well, I think. Better than I expected, actually. Maybe I underestimated her."* *GM note:* First public hint Richard told someone privately on Saturday afternoon. "Her" is unspecified. The room will speculate.

CLUE 2-2 • **□KEEP□** *Location:* Entryway — folded inside the inner pocket of Hank's jacket in the coat closet. *Content card:* A small scrap of dark green tweed fabric, torn from a jacket. (Use a snip of any green tweed-pattern fabric.) *GM note:* From Richard's jacket. Hank tore it during the gazebo shove and panicked. He's been hiding it. If anyone besides Hank finds it and shares it, his confession is forced earlier than planned. If Hank himself sees it found, he may try to grab it and hide it again.

CLUE 2-3 • **□KEEP□** *Location:* Kitchen — tucked behind the cookbooks on the open shelves. *Content card:* A typed letter fragment from Richard's attorney: *"...final draft of the trust beneficiary, as discussed. Per your instructions, this version replaces all prior. I'll bring the executed copy to the lake house Friday."* *GM note:* Confirms Richard recently changed his will. Doesn't reveal who or what. Both Hawthornes will want this hidden.

CLUE 2-4 • **□ANNOUNCE□** *Location:* Patio — under the upturned blue kayak. *Content card:* A printed "evidence photo" of a damp footprint, labeled: *MEN'S SIZE 11, FACING THE DOCK, FOUND ON THE PATIO STONES SUNDAY MORNING.* *GM note:* Doesn't narrow it down — Sebastian, Hank, and Beau all wear roughly that size. Red herring that points at three people.

CLUE 2-5 • [KEEP] *Location:* Living room — folded inside the small plant pot, tucked between the soil and the inner liner. *Content card:* A handwritten list in Richard’s writing, headed “*Gig Harbor Visit — Final List*”: seven names, six crossed out, one circled. The circled name is smudged into illegibility. *GM note:* Implies Richard had been narrowing down his beneficiary all weekend. The smudged name is intentional — keeps speculation open.

CLUE 2-6 • [KEEP] *Location:* Kitchen — inside the freezer, taped to the bottom of the ice cream tub. *Content card:* A grocery receipt from Friday in Richard’s name: *Solomon’s birdseed, 2x glass-bottle root beer (case), tortoise figurine, peppermint tea, lobster forks (3).* *GM note:* Pure flavor. The tortoise figurine seeds the TURD reveal indirectly. The lobster forks tie back to the engraved fork he’d sent Hank. Family will laugh.

CLUE 2-7 • [KEEP] *Location:* Dining area — taped to the underside of the bench with the decorative lanterns. *Content card:* A balled-up cocktail napkin with a shopping list scribbled and crossed out: “*plane tickets — NYC reservations — tortoise figurine — GONE.*” *GM note:* Vivi’s frustration written Saturday late afternoon. If anyone notices the handwriting matches Vivi, she’s exposed early. Vivi will desperately want to suppress this.

GM auto-reveals during Phase 2 discussion

Solomon’s First Outburst (*deliver mid-discussion*) Alexander brings Solomon out from the gazebo. Solomon screeches: “**WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!**” then mutters in a low voice: “*Don’t... don’t you talk about her like that...*” *GM note:* That second line is something Hank said in the gazebo at 8 PM. Hank is the only one who would have said it. The room’s eyes turn to Hank.

The Cleat (*deliver at end of discussion*) Alexander: “*Levi was good enough to dive for it this morning. The cleat was eight feet down, twelve feet off the dock. There’s dried blood on the underside. Dr. Langford is comparing it to the wound.*”

Forced Sinner confession in Phase 2

HANK — triggered by Solomon’s mutter and/or the green tweed fabric. *Confession script (Hank reveals when ready):* He admits he and Richard had a private confrontation in the gazebo around 8 PM Saturday. Richard had mocked Hank’s deceased parents and his ranch upbringing. Hank shoved him into a stack of life jackets. Solomon was watching. Hank has been sick about it all morning because he knows how it looks.

Mandatory Share at end of Phase 2

Each player must share one clue they found this phase, in turn. They choose which one if they have multiple.

PHASE 3 — The Investigation (40 min)

Bedrooms unlock, including Richard's guest room. Search round 2 (15 min). Discussion (10 min). Search round 3 (10 min). Discussion (5 min).

Hidden clues for Phase 3

CLUE 3-1 • [ANNOUNCE] *Location:* Patio — in the bonfire pit, in the cooled ash. (Place a small piece of singed paper in the ash before guests arrive Sunday morning.) *Content card:* A partially burned page of typed manuscript. Visible words: "...Aunt Catherine had always known the secret about her own mother, but the family pretended. She had decided this would be the year. The book would be her revenge wrapped in a memoir." *GM note:* A page from Catherine's tell-all family memoir. She burned the rest. Triggers her confession.

CLUE 3-2 • [ANNOUNCE] *Location:* Richard's guest room — on the desk, slightly tilted under a paperweight. *Content card:* A handwritten thank-you note: "Mr. Crookshank — Thank you for the book of your mother's poems. It meant more than you know. — E.H." *GM note:* Eden's note. Triggers her confession.

CLUE 3-3 • [KEEP] *Location:* Richard's guest room — inside the leather portfolio (now empty of envelope). *Content card:* A typed itinerary for Saturday with a handwritten note in the 3 PM slot: "Pull V aside — tell her about T. Be gentle. She'll understand." *GM note:* Big clue. "V" and "T" are unspecified. Players will speculate (Vivi/TURD? Or Vivi/Trust? Or Bella/Trip?). Vivi will desperately want to suppress this.

CLUE 3-4 • [KEEP] *Location:* Richard's guest room — top dresser drawer, under folded socks. *Content card:* An opened envelope addressed to "Vivienne H." in Richard's writing. Inside, a letter: "My dear Vivi — I read your last note. My answer is no, but let me explain. The theater is wonderful, but it doesn't pay rent in Manhattan, and I'm not in the business of subsidizing dreams. I love you for asking. — R." *GM note:* One of the letters Vivi was looking for. She doesn't know it was already opened by Richard. If found and revealed, Vivi has obvious motive showing. She'll try to grab and hide.

CLUE 3-5 • [KEEP] *Location:* Patio — in the recycling bin under newspapers. *Content card:* An empty glass-bottle root beer bottle. No label damage. No fingerprints. *GM note:* One of Beau's stolen stash. Eventually triggers his confession when combined with the case found later.

CLUE 3-6 • [ANNOUNCE] *Location:* Gazebo — under the cushion of the wicker chair where Solomon's perch sat. *Content card:* A torn page from the lake house guestbook with the visible lines: "Saturday — please let me know what you decide. Your support means the world. The kids in Cambodia need this. — Bella R." *GM note:* Hint Bella was asking Richard for something. Triggers Bella's secret.

CLUE 3-7 • [KEEP] *Location:* Levi's bedroom — under the mattress. *Content card:* A creased boarding ticket: *Lake Saunders Houseboat Marina — Slip 14, Saturday Night*

Card Game — Check-in 9:48 PM. GM note: Triggers Levi's confession. He snuck out. Alexander confirms he covered for him without knowing what for.

CLUE 3-8 • [ANNOUNCE] *Location:* Bottom floor — taped to the back of the orca mural (it has to be peeled forward, which Alexander permits in Phase 3). *Content card:* A hand-drawn diagram of the dock layout. "11:30 PM" circled at the bonfire. "11:50 PM" written below at the bonfire too. Between them, an arrow pointing to the dock. *GM note:* Major clue. Someone PLANNED this murder. The room realizes this was not a crime of passion. Both Hawthornes are panicking — they didn't know about this diagram. (GM truth: the diagram is real, drawn by Sebastian, hidden behind the mural. Either he or Vivi will want this clue suppressed at all costs.)

CLUE 3-9 • [KEEP] *Location:* Patio — under the second kayak (different from the foot-print kayak). *Content card:* A full case of glass-bottle root beer. Eleven bottles remaining. *GM note:* Beau's hidden stash. When discovered, his confession is forced. Solomon's "WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER!" lands like a punchline. Comic relief beat.

CLUE 3-10 • [KEEP] *Location:* Bottom floor games area — wedged inside a Monopoly box, between the rules booklet and the lid. *Content card:* A handwritten ledger page in Sebastian's small, neat handwriting. Two columns — left says "INHERITANCE (est.)" with figures totaling \$14M. Right says "OWED" with figures totaling \$1.2M (MBA loans, NYC apartment commitments, "private placement deposit"). Across the top: "Buffer ratio: 11.6x. Comfortable." *GM note:* Big incrimination of Sebastian. He was banking on the inheritance. If found, points hard at him. Sebastian will desperately want to hide this.

GM auto-reveal at end of Phase 3 discussion

Alexander's Photo Timeline Alexander hands the family his stack of photos from Saturday night. He has time-stamped a series of shots. The bonfire group photo at 11:35 PM shows six people. Sebastian is not in it. "*Sebastian — where were you in this photo?*" Sebastian's response: "*On the deck. Smoke break. I told everyone.*"

Forced Sinner confessions in Phase 3

- **CATHERINE** — triggered by the burned manuscript page. Confesses to writing a tell-all family memoir, sending an early draft to a publisher, finding out Richard had somehow obtained a copy, and slipping into his guest room around 9:30 PM Saturday to steal it back. She burned every page in the bonfire.
- **EDEN** — triggered by the thank-you note. **Surface confession only in Phase 3:** confesses she went to Richard's room around 9 PM to thank him for the book of his mother's poems he'd given her privately, and that he wasn't there. She does *not* reveal what she saw inside his portfolio. (*Her full confession lands in Phase 4 — see below.*)
- **BELLA** — triggered by the guestbook page. Confesses she'd been promised a \$250K donation to her humanitarian non-profit by Richard, found out Saturday afternoon

he'd been stringing her along, and confronted him alone in the gazebo at 7 PM. He laughed at her. She walked out fuming.

- **LEVI** — triggered by the boarding ticket. Confesses he was at his rich friends' three-tier houseboat 10 PM-12:30 AM playing poker (with chips, no money — *he keeps clarifying*). He convinced Alexander to cover for him without telling Alexander where he was actually going. Alexander confirms.
- **BEAU** — triggered by the root beer bottle and case. Confesses he stole the case at 10 PM as revenge for Richard humiliating him over a "Beau Thats Hot" merch pitch. Solomon screeches "*WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER!*" on cue. Whole table laughs.

Mandatory Share at each discussion in Phase 3

Each player shares one new clue they found in the most recent search round.

PHASE 4 — The Unmasking (30 min)

Primary suite unlocks. Alexander tells the family the case has stalled and they should search anywhere now. Search round 4 (10 min). Discussion + Cody's hero moment (10 min). First accusation vote (5 min). Reveal (5 min).

Hidden clues for Phase 4

CLUE 4-1 • **ANNOUNCE** *Location:* Dining area — inside the inner pocket of the navy blazer hanging on the back of Sebastian's breakfast chair. *Content card:* A heavy cream envelope, notary stamp visible, addressed to "Executor — Crookshank Inns Estate." Sealed. *GM note:* When opened by the family at the table, it is the will: "*I, Richard Carlton Crookshank, of sound mind and overflowing affection for the slowest creatures on God's earth, leave the entirety of my estate — Crookshank Inns and all assets — to TURD: the Tortoise Urgent Rescue Division, of Olympia, Washington.*" The room reads "TURD" aloud. The room reads it again. Sebastian's pen-clicking goes still.

CLUE 4-2 • **KEEP** *Location:* Same blazer pocket as 4-1, folded behind the envelope. *Content card:* A small scrap of paper with "*11:35 — go*" written in Vivi's handwriting. *GM note:* This implicates Vivi. If suppressed by whoever finds it, used in Phase 5. If shared, accelerates the architect reveal.

CLUE 4-3 • **ANNOUNCE** *Location:* Primary suite balcony (upper deck) — propped between the cushions of the loveseat. *Content card:* A pair of small black opera-style binoculars. Lens cap off, lens still warm from sun (or pretend-warm). *GM note:* Someone was watching the dock from this balcony at the time of the murder. The balcony has direct sightlines to the dock. This points hard at Vivi or anyone who was upstairs.

CLUE 4-4 • **KEEP** *Location:* Master bathroom of primary suite — in the trash, under tissues. *Content card:* A balled-up sticky note: "*breathe. it's done.*" *GM note:* Written

by Vivi at 11:55 PM after Sebastian came back. Devastating if revealed.

CLUE 4-5 • □KEEP□ *Location:* Bottom floor ping pong table — under the rim of the table on the kitchen-side. *Content card:* The bonfire group photo from Alexander, stamped 11:35 PM. Six people gathered around the fire. Sebastian is missing. Vivi is mid-gesture, mouth open, telling a story. *GM note:* Visualizes the alibi gap.

GM auto-reveal in Phase 4

Alexander's Smoke-Break Receipt *"Sebastian, you said you stepped out for a smoke at 11:30. I saw you come back in at 11:50. That's a twenty-minute cigarette."*

The Hero Turn — CODY's confession (and Eden's corroboration)

After Clue 4-1 surfaces (the envelope and TURD), and Clue 4-3 (the binoculars on the balcony), the room reels. Alexander turns to Cody, who has been quiet all morning. Alexander says, gently: *"Cody. Anything you've been holding onto? It's okay if you do."*

Cody pulls out his phone. The photo: a paper inside Richard's leather portfolio with *"\$60M → TURD (final)"* in Richard's handwriting. Time-stamped Saturday 2:14 PM.

Eden then steps forward. Quietly, she corroborates: she saw the same paper at 9 PM Saturday when she opened the portfolio in Richard's room. She didn't tell anyone because she had been promised privately that her grandparents were in the will, and the TURD paper proved Richard had lied to her face. Two witnesses now confirm what Richard's plan was. Beau's reaction lands hard.

This locks in the motive. The room has the means (cleat), opportunity (smoke break), and motive (the will going to TURD). Sebastian breaks. He confesses he killed Richard.

(Vivi tries to play stunned. She is good. Some players will believe her.)

First Accusation Vote

Alexander hands out paper ballots. Players write one name. Sebastian is named. He stands and confesses.

End Phase 4.

PHASE 5 — The Architect (15 min)

The room thinks the case is over. Alexander serves cake. *Then —*

The Christmas-Story Detail

GM auto-reveal:

Alexander, finishing a slice of cake, addresses Hank or Catherine: *“Did Vivi’s bonfire story sound familiar to either of you?”*

He plays a recording from his phone (or simply describes it in narration if you don’t want to record): Vivi’s Saturday-night Broadway story. He plays a second recording: the same exact story, told at last Christmas dinner.

The room turns to Vivi.

Final clues for Phase 5

CLUE 5-1 • [ANNOUNCE] *Location:* Vivi’s overnight bag — Alexander asks her permission to look. She refuses. Hank intervenes and authorizes the search. *Content card:* A draft letter in Vivi’s handwriting, never sent: *“Then I’ll have to find another way. — V”* *GM note:* Written Saturday afternoon after she got Richard’s “no” letter and before she walked back to find Sebastian. The chain is complete: she got the news, decided “another way,” found Sebastian, planned together.

CLUE 5-2 • [ANNOUNCE] *Location:* Re-introduce Clue 4-2 if it was suppressed: the “11:35 — go” note in Vivi’s handwriting. Whoever held it must reveal it now. *Content card:* (Same as 4-2.) *GM note:* The architect’s instruction. Time-coded.

Second Accusation Vote

Players vote a second name. Vivi is named. She confesses.

Final Scene

Alexander, holding Solomon, walks the family back through the entire Saturday afternoon Vivi-Richard conversation, the boathouse strategy session with Sebastian, the bonfire distraction, the dock, the envelope, and the crooked story Vivi has been building all morning. Solomon punctuates it with **“WHERE’S MY ROOT BEER!”**

End of game.

Sinner Confession Library (one per Sinner)

Concise version of each forced confession. Read aloud or paraphrased by the player when triggered.

Hank (triggered Phase 2): *“Yes. I shoved him. In the gazebo. Around 8. He was running his mouth about my dad and the ranch and I — I just shoved him. He landed in the life jackets. He laughed. I walked out. Solomon was watching. I am not proud. I am also not the man who killed him.”*

Catherine (triggered Phase 3): *"I have been writing a memoir. About this family. Yes. About all of us. I sent a draft to a publisher in March. I had no idea Richard had a copy until Friday night. I went to his room at 9:30 to take it back. I burned it page by page in the bonfire. I should have told you. I am sorry."*

Eden (triggered Phase 3): *"He gave me a book of his mother's poems on Friday. Privately. He said I reminded him of her. I didn't know how to tell anyone because of how he was treating Beau. I went to his room at nine to thank him. He wasn't there. I left a note. I rearranged a photo on his desk. That's all."*

Bella (triggered Phase 3): *"He told my non-profit he'd give us \$250,000 for a school in Cambodia. I came up here this weekend to lock it in. Saturday afternoon I found out he'd been lying. I confronted him in the gazebo at 7. He laughed at me. I left. I did not kill him. But I have been writing the apology email to my boss in my head all morning."*

Levi (triggered Phase 3): *"I wasn't here. I was on Wyatt's houseboat ten to twelve-thirty. We were playing cards. Chips. Not money. Not money. Alexander covered for me because I asked him to. I was not at the dock. I have proof on my phone."*

Beau (triggered Phase 3): *"Yes I took the root beer. He laughed at my merch pitch on Friday. Said it had the marketing instincts of a teen with a TikTok addiction. So I stole his case. It's under the second kayak. I drank one. Solomon saw me."*

Cody (Phase 4 hero turn): *"I went into his room Saturday afternoon. I just wanted to see what was in the leather thing. There was a paper. I took a picture. I didn't know what TURD was. I didn't tell anyone. I'm sorry. Here."*

GM Notes

- **Pacing.** If the room stalls, deploy Solomon. He is the panic button. *"WHERE'S MY ROOT BEER!"* always re-energizes.
- **Hoarding.** If players are hiding too many ☐KEEP☐ clues, the mandatory share at the end of each round forces motion. Don't let anyone "I didn't find anything" their way through it.
- **Murderer suppression.** If Vivi or Sebastian find a ☐KEEP☐ clue against them and suppress it, that clue still re-surfaces in Phase 5 via Alexander's authority. The clue is not lost.
- **Soft locks.** If a player tries to enter a locked room, Alexander politely intervenes. *"Mr. Whitfield asked me to keep that closed for now."*
- **Cody's moment.** Build him up. Look at him every time the room talks about Saturday afternoon. Give him weight. The youngest player should feel the spotlight when Alexander finally turns to him in Phase 4.
- **The Christmas story.** This detail is the finale's heart. If the GM forgets to plant the recording, just narrate it: *"Hank, you said something to me at breakfast — that*

Vivi told the same Broadway story at Christmas. Word for word."